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More than a year has passed since we did our last processor shootout, and the decision to schedule it close to the end of the year has paid rich dividends—we have a special first look at the Intel's new Quad Core Extreme QX6700.

Before we get into the core of the matter (pun intended), let's do a small recap of the things that have happened in the last year or so. To begin with, Intel's Pentium 4 processors were thrashed like never before by AMD's Athlon64 series. Marketing was still focused around the GigaHertz craze, with Intel promising to break the 4 GHz barrier, but their plans took a beating.

AMD, on the other hand, moved away from the traditional GigaHertz performance metric and proved that the key was in the architecture of the processor. Intel, not to be outdone, fired another salvo at AMD by launching the first Dual

core processor—two separate processors slapped on to one die—after all, the GigaHertz race held no significance now and there was need for a new buzzword. AMD shattered Intel's hope of dominance by launching their dual core Athlon64 X2 processors, which outstripped the Intel line by a mile.

Finally, now, Intel sets the scores right. The new desktop processors were redesigned from scratch and introduced as the 'Core' architecture. As we will see further in this article, no processor can stand up to the might of these new Core processors—they butcher the competition.

This isn't the last of AMD though; it's just the beginning of another battle. If the Hammer and Sickle changed the course of the Second World War, the Hammer and Core are sure to change the course of desktop computing. What we have experienced during the test is an unprecedented level of processing power made available on your little old desktop!

Let's begin the analysis with real world applications such as gaming and multimedia—the most taxing of the processors' tasks. Gaming and multimedia applications stress almost every part of the processor—the ALU, FPU and the Cache.

Greener Cores, Meaner Scores

We pitted the latest and fastest processors to grace the planet from AMD and Intel. To spice up the test, we also managed to get our hands on the yet to be launched Intel Quad Core processor—let the games begin!!

